

Google Ventures appoints Michael McBride as general partner

In a strategic move to enhance its support for innovative AI and open source startups, Google Ventures (GV), backed by Alphabet Inc., has appointed Michael McBride as its latest general partner. McBride, formerly the chief revenue officer at GitLab, will steer early-stage enterprises leveraging open source and AI technologies.

McBride, with five years at GitLab, a public open source developer tools firm in GV's portfolio, brings his experience to the forefront. "I've learned a lot about how open source can give startup and growth companies a big advantage. I think it's going to be a powerful business model in AI," he stated.

As venture capital funding faces challenges due to interest rate hikes and valuation adjustments, GV remains resilient, completing 125 investments in 2023, maintaining an annual average investment of £1 billion since 2020. Dave Munichiello, general partner at GV, underscored the firm's long-term and flexible approach. "We're long-term investors, and we have this flexibility to invest at any stage throughout a company's life, even after their IPO. We're unconstrained and we think of ourselves as aligning with what the very best founders need," he said.

Launched as Google Ventures in 2009, GV now manages £8 billion in assets under Alphabet, its sole limited partner. The 35-person investment team at GV, split between life science and digital focus, covers enterprise, consumer, and frontier tech in both the UK and Europe. With a track record of supporting successful companies like Uber and Slack, GV positions itself at the forefront of nurturing the next generation of AI and open source startups.



CrystalCoder emerges as a versatile programming assistant.

The unveiling of LLM360 is not only a testament to the collaborative spirit of the AI community but also positions the United Arab Emirates (UAE) as a burgeoning AI powerhouse.

Mistral AI receives \$415 million in funding

In a funding milestone, Paris-based Mistral AI has secured \$415 million, led by Andreessen Horowitz and Lightspeed Venture Partners. The startup, founded just six months ago, now boasts a valuation of 2 billion pounds.

Co-founders Timothée Lacroix, Guillaume Lample, and Arthur Mensch, with backgrounds in Meta Platforms Inc's Paris AI Lab and DeepMind, steer Mistral AI, a company that champions an open source ethos, sharing its large language models' code.

Anjney Midha of Andreessen Horowitz emphasised, "We just believe AI should be open." This philosophy sparks a broader AI community debate. Holger Mueller from Constellation Research Inc. noted, "Microsoft, Google, and OpenAI believe AI development should be closed, whereas Mistral AI believes it should be open source."



Efficiency and cost-effectiveness enhance Mistral AI's appeal. CEO Arthur Mensch stated their models operate at under half the cost of competitors like OpenAI and Google. Mistral AI's roadmap includes 'frontier models' for summarisation and question response.

As generative AI evolves, Mistral AI, with its open source stance, promises to challenge industry norms.

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